Zeno

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Arriving in Juhalerat

TWJ-01

The Winds of Juhalerat

Arriving in Juhalerat

Heavy footsteps echo down the hall.

A shackled man is escorted into a room, where he sits onto the stool behind him.

The interrogator gestures, and a guard removes his blindfold.

The sudden brightness stings the man, forcing him to drop his head to shield his eyes from the harsh glare.

Interrogation Room

Interrogator I: Private Aleksei Fyodorovich Ryleyev.

Interrogator I: Age, 24.

Interrogator I: Born in ... Rayashki. Ah, so you're a son of the North.

Interrogator I: A former law student at the Second Northern University, enlisted after earning his degree in 1982.

Interrogator I: Four months later, transferred to the Zeno Arms Academy for further training, and applied for the Juhalerat war front upon graduation.

Interrogator I: Served in the 756th Special Task Force of the 15th Battalion, stationed in Juhalerat by the Zeno Arms Academy.

Interrogator I: Rank, Private First Class.

Interrogator I: Length of service, three months.

A tedious formality that outlines the life of the person under scrutiny.

Aleksei nods to each statement in silence.

Next comes his crime.

Interrogator I: You are charged with ... shooting a comrade-in-arms.

Interrogator I: You voluntarily confessed to the crime, and Lieutenant Bertolt, the commander of the task force, proceeded to file the charges.

Aleksei: Yes.

Aleksei: I killed a comrade.

He says nothing more.

Bertolt: I never intended to report this.

Bertolt: But Aleksei insisted I do it. He came into my office with the written report and respectfully placed it in front of me.

Bertolt: "All you have to do is sign and report it, sir."

Bertolt: It was as if he were my superior, giving me a direct order.

Bertolt: But the man's integrity was unwavering, almost to a fault. I struggled to come up with a good reason to deny his request.

Lilya: That's him, alright. He's the kind of guy who believes in taking responsibility for your actions and facing the consequences.

Bertolt: The man is obsessed with "justice," like a bull fixated on the red cloth in front of him.

Bertolt: He may seem determined and honorable, but he is destined to be weakened and exhausted by the banderillas.

The two witnesses look into the interrogation room through the window.

Aleksei does not move his lips, answering only with nods while the two wait outside for their summons.

Bertolt: It's almost our turn.

Bertolt: You know, you and I are lucky to even be standing here today.

Lilya: I know. Death and sacrifice are the way things usually go.

After an impatient wait, they both look back into the room.

Lilya: How much longer until I can go in? Can these inefficient slowpokes hurry it up?

Lilya: I will not stand around like an idiot again, like when I first arrived in Juhalerat.

Bertolt: Calm down, soldier. Someone will call for you when it's your turn.

Bertolt: This is how it is in a war zone—nothing ever runs smoothly, and there's never enough of anything. You are not at the academy anymore.

Bertolt: We have lost a great deal to the "Storm."

The man stops, not wanting to complete the thought.

The Zeno Arms Academy in its current state resembles a bombed-out building, barely recognizable in its own rubble.

It's as if even the slightest rain could wash it all away.

Bertolt: We are facing shortages on all fronts—people, supplies, and shelter. Things may seem bleak, but it is in these challenging times that our loyalty truly shines.

Bertolt: Desperate times call for desperate measures, and that is why we find ourselves here, getting our hands dirty in the middle of this war zone.

Bertolt: Many clients entice us with offers that are too good to refuse—money, weapons, a place to stay, and most importantly, information.

Bertolt: And all we have to give in return are our soldiers—"currencies" that we'll lose anyway in the next reversal.

The girl looks at the figure through the glass.

Lilya: And the battlefield sharpens these "currencies" faster than any training ground.

Solemnly, the officer pats the girl on the shoulder.

Bertolt: Yes, comrade. Everyone dies, they just don't know when.

Lilya: Is Aleksei going to die?

Bertolt: To the death penalty? No, little falcon. It's not that serious of a matter.

Bertolt: He'll likely spend three years in prison, have his sentence reduced, and eventually be pardoned.

Bertolt: In any case, there are plenty of ways to get him out early. We're short-handed right now, and we're not going to let young blood waste away in prison like this.

Bertolt: And I have a feeling that the admiral will be interested in overseeing this case, so don't you worry.

Bertolt: He'll—

A clerk emerges from a room down the hall and signals to Lilya.

Bertolt: It looks like you're up first, little falcon. Go on, remember what I told you.

Bertolt: Be completely open with them. Tell the truth, for your own good and for Aleksei's and mine.

Lilya: Pfft. And I thought I was gonna get the whole hood-and-cuffs treatment, kicked into the room by steel-toed boots.

Bertolt: You want that kind of treatment? Easy, just blow my brains out in front of the guards right now.

Waving her hand, Lilya enters the room without looking back.

Lilya: Hah. We're better off staying alive, you and I. Later, Bertolt.

She pulls out a chair, hops onto it and crosses her legs, swinging her feet under the table.

Interrogator II: Miss Lilya, is it? There's no need to be nervous, young one. Help yourself to some candy in the drawer.

Interrogator II: And try not to kick the table. I doubt it could withstand much of your assault. Just take a deep breath and relax.

Lilya: Fine, fine. But do you have any adult potato juice around here? And don't call me "miss."

Interrogator II: No. Are you sure you should be consuming something like that?

Interrogator II: If you're thirsty, there's water in that cup. It's cold, but don't let that stop you.

Lilya: Tsk, forget it. Let's get started then, comrade. What do you want to ask?

Interrogator II: Private Aleksei Fyodorovich Ryleyev shot and killed a fellow soldier during a search-and-rescue mission outside of Juhalerat.

Interrogator II: You were there. Did you witness the act?

Lilya: Yes. I saw everything.

Interrogator II: Good.

Interrogator II: On June 12, Lieutenant Bertolt led the 756th squad into the mountains to rescue a trapped survey team.

Interrogator II: According to Lieutenant Bertolt's report, you joined the mission as a volunteer, is that right?

Lilya: Yeah, I went. Voluntarily.

Interrogator II: Private Aleksei's story and the lieutenant's report don't quite add up. We'd like more information, Comrade Lilya.

Good. She's not a little "miss" anymore.

Lilya: You ask, I'll answer.

Interrogator II: We're only going to ask about certain things, you see.

Interrogator II: Tell us everything you know, starting from the moment you landed in Juhalerat.

Interrogator II: We need the whole truth, every detail of what you saw and heard. Please, comrade.

TO BE CONTINUED...

Zeno Speed

TWJ-02

Zeno Speed

Lilya: They wanted to send rookies into the war zone to get some hands-on experience. I signed up and proved myself better than most, so they let me go.

Lilya: I was part of the third group.

Lilya: When? Saturday, probably. I don't remember. Anyway, it was around noon when we got off the plane.

Lilya: The sun, the sizzling sand, and a bunch of rookies. Ah, Juhalerat sure knew how to give us a warm welcome.

Lilya: Before we took off, some of the recruits saw black coffins being unloaded off a plane. They started to panic.

Lilya: When they found out that the coffins held the remains of the previous group of rookies, even more chickened out.

Lilya: In the end, I was the only one who flew to Juhalerat, carrying the experimental equipment that the others were supposed to handle.

Lilya: I guess the instructor wanted to use me to test their new toys out in the field.

Lilya: Those fist-sized boom bombs, packed with volatile Efreetine, could turn a giant boulder into a pile of confetti.

Lilya: It was probably because I can fly that they dared to trust me with those things.

Lilya: And then there was this tiny radar, modified from the Type 76 experimental bug, which picked up preset channels. It was Zeno's latest masterpiece.

Lilya: I was excited at first, thinking I was gonna do something big there.

Lilya: Maybe snag a few shiny medals to show off to the wimps back at the academy.

Lilya: You know, because only the toughest soldiers deserve to be sent to the front lines.

City, Juhalerat

Lilya: Juhalerat was a dump of a city. I got off the plane and then onto a truck.

Lilya: I thought it'd be all dirt and grime, like the mud caked on their truck tires.

Lilya: Turned out, there were more trees than I'd thought.

Lilya: The mountains outside the city shone with a pale white glow, like shrapnel glinting in the sun.

Lilya: "The mighty Hindu Kush, where even eagles dare not fly." So exclaimed the instructor before we left.

Lilya: I still remember the silence in the truck, everyone keeping their mouths shut. I figured it was 'cause of the dust on the road.

Lilya: Soon enough, the truck stopped, the driver cursing and honking at us to get off.

Lilya: And then there we stood, like a bunch of imbeciles, dazed and confused under the scorching sun of Juhalerat.

Lilya: Seriously? Is no one coming to pick us up? Did they just throw us off the truck and leave us here?

Lilya: Hello? Comrade? Shouldn't someone be coming to take us to the base?

Lilya: Hey, comrade. Do you know the way? Here, the way to here.

Lilya: I chatted with a few people and showed them the map in my pocket, but nobody seemed to care.

Lilya: They looked at me as if I were a rabbit, but when's the last time you saw a rabbit with the talons of a hawk?

Lilya: Well, I guess our local comrades must've been busy. How could they spare someone to pick us up when they were at war?

Lilya: Or maybe they just forgot about us. Anyway, I kept waiting and waiting, for the longest, longest time ...

Lilya: For ten freaking minutes! When the blistering sun finally got to me, I decided I wasn't going to stand around like an idiot any longer!

Lilya: Alright, guess this is where we part ways, comrades. Good luck! Всего хорошего!

Lilya: I had a letter and a map in my pocket, though all soaked from my leaky bottle. But that was okay, they were still readable.

Lilya: I followed the map aimlessly around the city, feeling like I was going in circles.

Lilya: Until a kind local recognized my uniform and stopped me in the street.

Kind Local: You are from Zeno, yes? Welcome, friend!

Kind Local: Are you going to the base? It's not far ahead. Just go straight for 120 steps, turn into the alley with the red wall, and continue for another 210 steps.

Kind Local: Then turn right and come to an intersection with two sacred figs. Turn right again and you will find Farouk's tea shop. Go down the steps next to the shop, then turn left and walk fifty steps ...

Lilya: He was like an enthusiastic tour guide, giving me all the details.

Kind Local: Be careful in the narrow alley and don't trip over the melons on the ground stall, or you'll be an easy target for the old man who'll try to swindle you of everything you have!

Kind Local: When you smell fried chickpeas, follow the aroma. Oh, and maybe buy some while you're there, help out her business? They're tasty!

Kind Local: And finally, when you see a couple of guys crouching by a courtyard wall, that's the base!

Lilya: But it's nothing like that on the map.

Kind Local: Juhalerat changes every day, my friend. It's better to trust me than to trust your map.

Lilya: So I took a leap of faith. I trusted the guy.

Zeno Base, Juhalerat

Lilya: Truth be told, the place was pretty shabby. They were houses taken over from civilians, mostly.

Lilya: A perimeter wall, two courtyards, a few rows of converted barracks, and one "office."

Lilya: Several men squatted outside the wall, killing time and eyeing me as I walked in.

Lilya: The guard on duty was dozing off in the shade, rifle on his lap.

Lilya: Wake up. You're on watch.

Lilya: I nudged the slacker with my boot. He gave me a stink eye in return and went right back to sleep.

Soldier: Don't start any trouble, little girl. Go play somewhere else.

Lilya: I'm here for Bertolt.

Lilya: Hearing Bertolt's name, he squinted and stretched out a finger, pointing into the courtyard.

Soldier: Third house from the left, he's in there. Go ahead.

Lilya: But before I could find Bertolt, he found me first.

A uniformed gentleman emerges from the house and catches sight of the young recruit.

The unfamiliar recruit runs up to the officer, handing over a letter. The piece of yellow paper is now dried out by the heat of Juhalerat's sun.

Bertolt: You new here?

Bertolt: A Zeno Air Force Reserve cadet. Hmm, good. A little falcon chick.

Bertolt: Think you can fly over the Hindu Kush? We've had many great pilots take on the mountains, but not all have made it back.

Bertolt: Be very careful. The mountain folk here have been hunting fierce beasts and birds for thousands of years, including eagles and falcons alike.

Lilya: Compared to the careless, unreliable nature of this place, Bertolt seemed to be the most dependable soldier around.

Bertolt: It's too bad you came at a bad time. I'm about to go on a mission, no time to take you under my wing, I'm afraid.

Bertolt: No one can guarantee their own safe return from the next mission, rookie. You should prepare yourself for any outcome.

The girl's interest ignites.

Lilya: A mission? Then I've come at the right time. Sir, I'm here to fight, so take me with you!

Bertolt: You want to come along?

Lilya: Why else would I be here? To kick rocks, shoot targets, and shuffle files all day?

Bertolt: Hah. For the menial tasks, you can leave them to the others. Just holler at the gate and you'll have more help than you know what to do with.

Bertolt: If you want to come, come. By the way, tell me, little falcon, what does loyalty mean to you?

Lilya: Not afraid of dying for a cause.

Bertolt: Right you are, but on the battlefield, "loyalty" is much more complicated than that.

Bertolt: As for sacrifice ... Sacrifice is loyalty, and loyalty is sacrifice. Let's go with that. Come, little friend, I've gathered everyone. Let's go meet them.

A dozen soldiers are waiting in another part of the courtyard. Bertolt walks up to them with Lilya.

He starts a head count, only to find that one person is missing.

Bertolt: Where's Hassan?!

Young Man: He said he was heading out to buy tea half an hour ago.

Bertolt: Did he seriously expect us to tolerate his frequent tea breaks that waste our time?

Just as the words leave his mouth, a robed man hurries over from the opposite side of the courtyard.

Hassan: I'm here, boss! Hassan's here!

Lilya: The tardy soldier, Hassan, turned out to be the same guy who showed me the way to the base.

Young Man: It was your turn to stand guard today, Comrade Hassan.

Hassan: Me? Yes, it was my turn, but Abu said he'd cover for me. And isn't he doing a wonderful job standing guard over there? No need to worry, brother Aleksei!

Aleksei: When it's your turn, it's your turn! Those are the rules!

Bertolt: Enough. Time is ticking. Aleksei, get the first aid kit ready. The rest of you, grab your gear. The truck will be here in five minutes.

Lilya: Time had its own rhythm in Juhalerat. Waiting for five minutes there was more like waiting for fifteen.

Lilya: Fifteen minutes minimum.

Hassan: And what should I do, boss?

Bertolt: Get acquainted with our new friend and keep her safe until the mission is over.

Lilya: Scram. I don't need no babysitter.

Hassan: Wow, boss, look at her! She's a fierce little thing. Ha!

Hassan: When my sister was her age, she didn't even dare to talk to people while herding sheep up in the mountains. Hahaha!

Aleksei: Show a little more respect for our comrade, Hassan.

Aleksei: Hey there, what's your name?

Bertolt: Her name is Lilya. She's from the academy, just like you.

Aleksei: That's fantastic news! I actually just graduated from there. Did you apply for the base yourself?

Lilya: Kind of. I beat a lot of people, so they let me come here.

Aleksei: Uh, I'm not sure what that means. I can't imagine what you've gone through to get here, but you must have some serious skills.

Hassan: Oh, she's a "tough cookie," Aleksei, that's what they say nowadays!

The robed man seems quite friendly to Aleksei. Or perhaps he's just "friendly" to everyone.

Hassan: Some say that brother Aleksei looks scary, but don't worry, he's actually a good man, haha!

Hassan: He hands out candy and plays ball with the kids, smiles at everyone, speaks kindly, and even pays the locals a fair price with real money.

Aleksei: Outsiders have done too many terrible things in this place. The people resent us.

Aleksei: It should not be like this, it should not be ... We were supposed to be here to help them defend their homes, to help them build their city.

Aleksei: War makes good men better and bad men worse. Some of our comrades, and I'm ashamed to call them comrades, are downright criminals.

Hassan: It's always been like that, war. Always like that.

Aleksei: Those thugs all deserve to be shot!

After their brief spat, Aleksei turns his attention back to Lilya with a warm and attentive gaze.

Aleksei: I ... may have said too much. Let's save the rest for later, young comrade, when we're on the road and can get to know each other better. I'll see you soon.

Hassan: If he had lived 500 years ago, he would've been the most devout ascetic of his time. Don't you agree, friend?

Lilya: He totally would have.

Aleksei hurries to the house while the others keep busy at camp, waiting for the borrowed truck from their allies.

The commander pulls the eager little falcon aside for a private word.

Lilya: What's the plan, sir?

Bertolt: Lilya, let's talk about courage. It is a great virtue, and I have no doubt about your own courage.

Bertolt: But there is no need for you to quench the fire with your own blood.

Lilya: Speak plainly, sir.

Bertolt pauses, gathering his thoughts before speaking carefully.

Bertolt: I appreciate your enthusiasm to join us on this mission, but as young blood with so much potential, you and Aleksei are the true future of Zeno.

Bertolt: And we must preserve those sparks.

Bertolt: A wise warrior knows when to attack, just as they know when to decisively retreat.

The commander's words are tactful, but the hint of underestimation infuriates the battle-hungry youth.

Lilya: What, you want me to punk out? Not way, I'm no chicken! I'm tough as nails, just like you guys!

She does not need anyone's protection. Never has, never will.

Bertolt: Chicken? That's not the right word, little falcon. I trust your tactical acumen and your willingness to sacrifice for the cause, but I don't want you to be the one to bear that burden.

Bertolt: If things go south, take your broom and fly away as fast as you can. My people will cover you. Don't throw your life away here. You have to survive.

Lilya: Your people? Sir. I'm one of you.

Bertolt: Alright, your comrades will cover you. But when I give the order to retreat, obey my command, Comrade Lilya.

Lilya: Bertolt left me no room to argue. He was my commander, and I was his soldier.

Lilya: I had to comply.

Lilya: But I still felt he underestimated me.

The truck finally pulls up and the team assembles. Before they leave, Bertolt outlines the mission.

Bertolt: We are on our way to save a team of comrades. They have been trapped in the mountains by unfriendly, armed forces stirring up trouble.

Bertolt: Retrieve our people and the documents they've recovered, and eliminate all obstacles in your way. You know what must be done.

Bertolt: That's all, comrades. Get on the truck and head out. Best of luck to us all.

Lilya: But Bertolt lied.

Interrogator II: Stop. What do you mean by "Bertolt lied"?

Lilya: While our objectives were "search and rescue" and "recovery," he lied to the soldiers.

The interrogator nods and turns to signal the clerk.

Interrogator II: So who or what were you actually trying to save? Important arcanists, or something else?

Lilya: Documents lost during war.

Lilya: Anyway, that's what Bertolt told to me after; they were his real objective.

Lilya: And those unlucky comrades were just regrettable, necessary losses.

TO BE CONTINUED...

The Talking Mountain

TWJ-03

The Talking Mountain

Lilya: To save our comrades stranded in the mountains, we left the city by truck.

Lilya: A road was built outside the city, with our outposts and supply stations scattered along its route.

Lilya: The locals often came down from the mountains to trade with our people.

Lilya: Exchanging pretty stones for clothes, wool, and kisses for paper clips or old shoes—things that weren't worth much.

Interrogator II: Speak slowly, take your time.

Lilya: As our truck left the city, we passed a demolished tank by the side of the road.

Lilya: Not long after, the driver said we were running low on fuel.

Lilya: Lucky for us, a gas station was not far, guarded by troops like all the others.

Lilya: We hopped out and watched our truck slowly make its way over.

Lilya: Everyone was relaxed and having a good time, chatting and laughing by the roadside, waiting for the truck to fill up and roll back around.

Lilya: Why'd we all have to get out of the truck?

Bertolt: Because when the truck blows up, it's safer out here than it is in there.

Bertolt: To our foes hiding in the mountains, destroying a vehicle can be more valuable than taking lives.

Hassan: Don't scare the rookie, boss. It's a beautiful day, sunny and bright. Nothing bad is gonna happen.

Bertolt: Heh. It does feel good to stand here and soak up the sun, you might even grow a little taller.

Bertolt: Last month, our allies cleared out the nearby villages because they were supporting our enemies. So we have nothing to worry about, comrades. Relax and enjoy the sunshine!

Hassan: We have been blessed with a peaceful day, haven't we, brother Aleksei? This is all thanks to your good fortune!

Aleksei: Stay alert, Comrade Hassan. Keep your eyes on the mountains.

Lilya: Among us, Aleksei was always the most on edge, while Hassan was the most relaxed.

Lilya: They didn't care whether I was a human or an arcanist. They only asked what unit I was in and where I served.

Lilya: But not one of them even glanced at my Red-38! Hello? A broom of mass destruction over here, the ultimate ride! They weren't even the least bit curious about that?!

Lilya: Imagine if they saw Zeno's arsenal, with flying carpets that breathe fire and ropes that seek out enemies, their jaws would hit the sand! Hah!

Lilya: But none of that stuff is as good as my trusty broom!

Hassan: Before joining Zeno, I was begging on the streets of Juhalerat. Each day was either feast or famine, a roll of the dice. That was just how life was, haha!

Hassan: But then one day, they came up to me and said, "Hey, kid, you want to join the army? We'll feed you! Three meals a day!" So I signed up.

Lilya: Chatty Hassan, always so talkative.

Hassan: Loyalty is easily bought over here. All it took was one pair of boots, two bowls of pilaf, and three square meals a day.

Hassan: After that, people from Zeno taught me to read and write, and told me all kinds of old stories.

Hassan: You know, just a friendly advice, be careful. It's okay to give gifts to the locals, but make sure you never take anything they give you.

Hassan: If you're lucky, it's poison; if not, it's a bomb.

Hassan: Music boxes and dolls might just blow up in your hand.

Hassan: Did I scare you? No need to be afraid, haha! Welcome to Juhalerat, Comrade Lilya! May you live a hundred years!

Lilya: I've heard all of that before. Who do you think you're tryna spook?

Hassan: Yes, yes, you're a brave one! You are! By the way, where did you serve before?

Aleksei: She's like me, a student from Zeno.

Lilya: Air Force Reserves.

Hassan: A fledgling falcon, ready to spread her wings! Did you fly here on this broomstick?

Lilya: Hassan caressed my Red-38, gently patting its metallic casing.

Hassan: This thing, you sit on it, and it really flies? That's the coolest thing ever, friend!

Lilya: Want me to show you?

Lilya: The curious crowd gathered around me, like spectators waiting for a show.

Lilya: The clear skies, mountain roads, and the valleys between the peaks were like a perfect runway.

Bertolt: Go on, see if you really have the eyes of a hawk. Scout the mountains. We're counting on you.

Lilya: Roger that, Commander!

Lilya: Everyone cleared a path for me, and then my magnificent Red-38 and I took to the skies.

Lilya: I heard cheers as I lifted off, or maybe they were gasps.

Lilya: There was nothing but mountains and trees out there, but it wasn't as barren as I thought. In the distance, a light was reflecting from the forest.

Lilya: The shepherds and villagers in the mountains seemed to have noticed me, and looked my way from afar.

Lilya: I waved, but I doubt they saw that.

Lilya: After circling the mountains, I returned to the ground to save fuel.

Hassan: Ha! Ha! Can you take Hassan flying too? I've always wanted to see the sky!

Soldier: Hassan, man, you'd probably pee your pants, hahaha!

Hassan: What're you talking about? Hassan's braver than a lion! What's a little flight to me? The lives that have fallen by my hand are more numerous than the sheep you've eaten for dinner!

Aleksei: That's not something to brag about, Comrade Hassan.

Aleksei: You know, after the war, you can fly back to the Zeno Arms Academy with us on a special plane.

Hassan: Yes! Of course I will! That's what you promised, right, boss?

Lilya: Bertolt smiled and nodded, then checked his watch again. He seemed uneasy.

Aleksei: Sit next to me on the plane. I'll have a barf bag and stale crackers ready for your somersaulting stomach. Hah!

Lilya: Laughter erupted from the crowd. Hassan grinned too, showing his yellow teeth and cackling so hard that even Bertolt cracked a smile.

Lilya: Outside Juhalerat, the sun shone brightly as eagles glided across the blue sky.

Lilya: The truck was parked at the gas station, with a few people going about their business. It seemed like an easy job.

Hassan: We really are lucky this time, all thanks to our little comrade, the goddess of luck! No mines or bombs, and no—

He spoke too soon.

A massive explosion erupts ahead, followed by two more in quick succession.

Lilya: That's the РПГ-8Д84! I'd recognize that sound anywhere! One rocket, three blasts.

Bertolt: It's time for action, comrades!

Lilya: The shock wave from the explosion of the truck and gas station left my ears ringing. I couldn't hear a thing.

Lilya: But our comrades were quick to react. Hassan and two others had already found cover and started shooting up the hill.

Lilya: Aleksei helped up a comrade who'd been knocked down by the blast, but thankfully they were a safe distance away.

Lilya: All in all, we lost a truck and a driver, nothing else.

Lilya: But now we were caught with our pants down, and bullets started flying.

Hassan: I just had to go and jinx us!

Lilya: How did they get their hands on those things?

Hassan: By the humps of a stubborn camel, how should I know? See that guy up there? Shoot back, boys! Open your eyes and aim, you sightless donkeys!

Lilya: We returned fire, but we were too far apart to hit each other. Despite the fierce exchange, none of us were injured in the slightest.

Lilya: About the РПГ-8Д84. It is an eighth generation portable rocket launcher, developed by the Zeno Arms Academy and issued in the fall of '84.

Lilya: Believe me, these are some of the most intelligent rockets you'll ever see.

Lilya: Amidst the deafening roars of wind and screeching, these explosives never fail to find their target.

Lilya: I've played with these back at the academy. Powerful stuff, but luckily they're one-offs, and each one is a pain to cultivate.

Lilya: But seriously, how the hell did the enemy get their hands on those things?

Interrogator II: So, are you saying that Zeno's arcanum weapons have fallen into enemy hands?

Lilya: Good question. I wonder what really happened, comrade.

Interrogator II: We'll make a note of that.

Lilya: There was more. They all had Zeno uniforms as well.

Interrogator II: Hm. We recently shipped a new batch of uniforms to the front lines, as recorded by the logistics department.

Interrogator II: Some units have temporarily recruited local personnel to join their auxiliary forces. They needed Zeno's uniforms.

Lilya: A new batch of uniforms? No, that doesn't make sense. Hassan was still wearing his own clothes, and so were a bunch of other comrades!

Hearing this, the interrogator turns to the clerk, who nods in understanding.

Lilya: They retreated, and the shooting stopped.

Bertolt: Is anyone hurt?

Hassan: Boss? All the radio equipment were on the truck, but now they're gone.

The officer grimaces as he watches the smoke disperse. The truck and surrounding buildings continue to burn uncontrollably in the distance.

Aleksei: The explosion was far from us, sir. The driver and the comrades at the gas station are gone, but our people here are unharmed.

The soldiers regroup, the most unfortunate among them sporting only a scratch on his arm.

Bertolt: The good news is we survived unscathed. The bad news is we've now lost contact with the trapped party.

Lilya: Bertolt forgot that he still had me.

Lilya: Was the distress signal on a military channel?

Bertolt: Yes, an encrypted one. Do you have a plan, little falcon chick?

Lilya: The experimental navigation radar ПВ-1182, a new gadget devised by Zeno's arcanists. Let's give it a try, it should be able to pick up a signal.

Lilya: The creatures in the radar are highly trained. Certain frequencies can activate their dormant minds, prompting them to react accordingly.

Bertolt: Let me see that.

The soldiers begin to murmur at the mention of arcanists.

Bertolt: There it is! But what happened? Why has the signal stopped in place?

Lilya: It might be unstable. It's still a prototype, after all.

Bertolt: Well, it's better than nothing.

Aleksei: We were fortunate to have you here, Comrade Lilya!

Aleksei: But we no longer have a vehicle.

Hassan: If you don't have wheels, use your legs! Are you scared, brother Aleksei? Our people have been traversing these mountains for thousands of years!

Bertolt: He's right. Let's go. We'll follow where this thing goes.

Lilya: So off we went, toward the billowing smoke of the gas station.

Lilya: The atmosphere had changed. There were no more jokes or laughter, just pairs of watchful soldiers, their eyes fixed on the hills.

Lilya: There's trees on that hill there. Maybe people there too.

Hassan: I wasn't wrong, comrade, we really are lucky to be alive.

Hassan: Let me give you some advice. I know it's going to sound morbid, but you'd best keep a bullet for yourself, little comrade.

Lilya: I'd rather jam my last bullet up an enemy's nostril.

Hassan: Hahaha! But seriously, don't get caught alive, or you'll wish you'd died.

Hassan: Bullets are merciful things! A bang, and you're gone, no pain at all! I've seen way too many soldiers in the infirmary, wailing in pain.

Hassan: I remember the missing limbs, such a pitiful sight. Lying in bed, calling out names, crying for their mothers.

Lilya: I noticed a glimmer of tears in his eyes, but he quickly composed himself and burst into a mischievous laughter.

Hassan: Those fiends torture their captives with blades coated in poison. I hear they have skilled arcanists who use cruel arts to leave their victims unable to live or die.

Hassan: For us here, blood is thicker than water. If someone hurts your family, you have to seek vengeance at any cost.

Hassan: You afraid yet? Ha, even the city isn't safe! Just remember, my young friend, never take anything from someone you don't know.

Hassan: Even a lighter—press it and boom! Blow you to bits.

Lilya: Get lost with your scare tactics, you've already told me that!

Hassan: Believe it or not, your choice.

The old soldier shrugs and pulls a handful of roasted beans from his pocket.

Hassan: Want some? They may be cold, but they're still good. My wife fried them with salt! They're tasty!

Lilya: So there we were, a group of survivors, nibbling on chickpeas as we continued on our way.

Hassan: Just a few beans is enough, indulge in too many and you'll be tooting like a tuba! Haha!

Lilya: As we passed the remains of the gas station, we all instinctively covered our faces from the thick, black smoke.

Lilya: We did not have the time to mourn.

Aleksei: Maybe there are still survivors.

Hassan: Impossible, absolutely impossible. Nothing could have survived such an explosion. You would have to be some kind of monster!

Lilya: But Aleksei did find a survivor.

Lilya: Though she wasn't one of ours.

Aleksei: Look over there! I think I see someone!

Bertolt: Aleksei!

Aleksei sprints ahead, too fast to be stopped. Bertolt quickly signals to follow.

Aleksei: Are you alright, miss?

The woman lies on the ground, eyes wide with terror. Her calf is cut by broken stones, bleeding profusely.

She looks like a frightened lamb, with a flock of unfortunate real lambs lying next to her, none spared by the explosion.

Aleksei: You're hurt. Stay calm, I'll take care of it.

Aleksei crouches down, pulls out a first aid kit, and carefully tends to the woman's wounds.

Aleksei: The disinfectant will sting a bit, but don't worry, I'll stop the bleeding first. Your injury is manageable, I've practiced this at the academy before.

Hassan: I think I see blood.

Aleksei kneels beside her, gently cleansing the wound and using precious cotton swabs to apply medicine before carefully wrapping it in a bandage.

Lilya: As we caught up with Aleksei and approached the scene, the woman became even more frightened at the sight of armed soldiers.

Hassan: She's from the hills.

When Hassan sees the woman in local dress, he unslings his rifle, loads it, and points it at her.

Aleksei: What are you even doing? She doesn't have a gun! And she's hurt!

Aleksei jumps up and stands in front of the gun, using his own body to shield the frightened woman behind him.

Hassan: She comes from the hills, brother! There's a good chance she's a spy for "them"!

Aleksei: Hassan, please! She's just a simple herder caught up in this terrible war! She's injured and defenseless!

Hassan: Are you out of your mind?! Think, brother Aleksei! Whatever is in your box is all that we have left!

The explosion had taken their truck, driver, radio equipment, and all their first aid supplies.

Aleksei: Listen to yourself! Are you telling me to leave her here to die? Just walk past a wounded lady on the roadside like she isn't even there?

Aleksei: She could just be a herder passing through to trade, and now her sheep are gone, all thanks to that d**n explosion!

Hassan: There are herbs in the hills that can stop bleeding, and my ancestors have been using them for centuries. She's a hill person, she can take care of herself.

Aleksei: Do you really think she can survive through the hills with that injured leg?

Hassan: #@&$! Why do you have to be such a crazy do-gooder, Aleksei?

Lilya: They were at each other's throats, but I didn't think Aleksei was wrong at the time.

Lilya: Bertolt stepped in to break it up.

Bertolt: That's enough. I believe this lady can find her way home now. We have other matters to attend to.

Bertolt: Time is ticking, comrades. Our fellow soldiers in the cave are still waiting for us.

Hassan: I'm not sure if we should leave a loose end like this, boss. What if one of her family members is an enemy of ours?

Aleksei: Did you just say loose end? It'll have to be over my dead body, Hassan!

Bertolt: That's enough. Put away your gun, Hassan. And Aleksei, step away from her. Pack up the kit and medicine.

Bertolt: She's a victim just like us, nearly killed in the attack. Let's leave it at that.

Hassan: I can only hope you're right.

Hassan sighs and slings his rifle back over his shoulder.

Hassan: If we were in the time of Nader Shah, our brother Aleksei would have been a great knight.

Hassan: But now, your kindness just might get us killed, Aleksei.

Aleksei: And your lack of empathy is killing Zeno and its future here, Hassan.

Lilya: After that, we continued on our way.

Lilya: Aleksei followed closely behind Hassan, glancing back every few steps until the woman limped out of sight and into the mountains. Only then did he seem to relax.

Lilya: Our Aleksei is a good man, maybe even better than some of the other good men I know.

Lilya: Hassan, on the other hand, was reliable and experienced. I couldn't help but wonder what he had been through.

TO BE CONTINUED...

The Distrusted

TWJ-04

The Distrusted

Interrogator III: Bertolt, age ...

Bertolt: Shall we skip the formalities and get started, comrade? Let's not waste each other's time.

The officer interrupts with soldier-like efficiency.

The interrogator's face sours. He does not enjoy the disruption of his tiny sense of authority.

Bertolt: How's our soldier faring in captivity? Can you give me a glimpse of the outcome, comrade?

Interrogator III: Private Aleksei is calm, coherent, and cooperating with the interrogation. My role is only to interrogate, the verdict is up to the judiciary.

Bertolt: But the judge is going to need you to provide the evidence.

Interrogator III: Yes, but the outcome is more up to you and your subordinates. My submission will be shaped by your narrative.

Bertolt: Fine. Rest assured, you will learn what you want to know.

Bertolt: By the way, how's the girl?

Interrogator III: Miss Lilya is in another room for questioning. Don't worry, we treat our trainees with care, especially since she's so young.

Bertolt: Those who've experienced war and artillery fire can hardly be called "young" anymore.

Interrogator III: Personally, I agree with this sentiment, but that's a topic for another day. As you said, let's not waste time.

The interrogator takes out another set of documents.

Interrogator III: The prisoner mentioned that you saved a local civilian after the explosion, which led to an argument. What happened after that?

Interrogator III: What happened between Private Aleksei and the auxiliary soldier Hassan, both of whom were your subordinates?

Bertolt: Nothing much. Just an ordinary quarrel between comrades, like an everyday quarrel you might have with your wife.

Bertolt: Honestly, you guys out here, assigned so far from the front lines, can sometimes get a little too ... well, you know.

Hearing this, the interrogator loosens his collar, revealing the scars on his neck and chest.

Interrogator III: Two years ago, we were pulling out of the mountain pass. My squad was responsible for covering the rear and fending off pursuit.

Interrogator III: After the shooting subsided, only two of us survived in that valley—myself, and the officer I later carried back to base safely.

Interrogator III: That's the end of that story.

Interrogator III: The Military Discipline Department is still waiting for our report. We need to wrap up this case quickly, as the higher-ups expect us to work efficiently.

Interrogator III: The admiral wants us to tighten military discipline, and all the bases currently have problems that our oversight team must solve.

Interrogator III: You should understand that a bunch of armed thugs can't be called an army unless they're firmly bound by discipline and order.

Interrogator III: This is especially important when it comes to those unstable arcanists.

Interrogator III: Strictly speaking, interrogations like this should be handled by the Interrogations Department, but for the time being, we are tasked with this duty.

Interrogator III: You've been on the front lines. You should understand Zeno's current predicament better than most. We have lost too many of our comrades in the "Storm."

Interrogator III: Please continue, Lieutenant.

The officer pauses for a moment, then speaks again.

Bertolt: To retrieve the lost documents hidden in the valley, we ventured deep into the mountains, searching for our target.

Bertolt: Such was the directive from the headquarters.

In the Mountains, Juhalerat

Bertolt: A month ago, we received an order to clear both sides of the road in the mountains—to leave not a single tree standing. But no one bothered to do it.

Bertolt: So when we left the wilderness and followed a trail deeper into the forest, everyone was on high alert.

Bertolt: We spoke little. The chirping of birds filled the silence, taking me back to those long summer days in Odessa.

Bertolt: Lilya's device guided us, but in that place, knowing the direction and finding an actual path were two different things.

Aleksei: My hometown doesn't have nearly as many trees as this, my little comrade.

Aleksei: I'm from Rayashki. You know the place? A cold, faraway little town that has a partnership with Zeno.

Aleksei: Maybe it was because to this connection that I was chosen as a new recruit for advanced training at the Zeno Arms Academy.

Bertolt: You never told me, Comrade Aleksei.

Aleksei: I thought you knew, sir. Didn't all of our files pass through your hands?

Lilya: You didn't know?

Bertolt: I don't pay much mind to these things, but Rayashki is a nice place. I've been there before.

Aleksei: You've actually been there?!

Bertolt: Indeed. The people there are united, brave, and kind, forging a homeland that is both strong and splendid.

Aleksei: That's wonderful! Truth be told, it's been years since I've been home.

Bertolt: In two months you will be able to take your leave and return home. Rayashki is thriving now, and I'm sure your mother has been eagerly waiting for your arrival.

Aleksei: She's always worried about me, sending letters and money ... but I don't need the money. Her letters are more important.

Aleksei: Hah, my father thinks she's a overreacting. Having a son on the front lines is an honor, a mother shouldn't worry so much.

Aleksei: All the men in our family have served. My father was also in Zeno's forces, but he retired a few years ago after returning from Prague.

Aleksei: And my grandfather was a war hero. He earned his medals in Bialystok.

When talking about home and family, Aleksei's face lights up with a bright smile.

Lilya: Your whole family is incredible, Aleksei.

Aleksei: Yes, and we have never compromised our principles—from my grandfather, to my father, to me, and hopefully to ... to my future son.

He blushes at this point, looking a bit timid.

Bertolt: Zeno is truly grateful for you and your father's service, Aleksei.

Aleksei: Service? No, Commander. We call it allegiance! Our loyalty is eternal!

Bertolt: Aleksei is a young man of unshakable convictions, untainted by the various vices of the barracks.

Bertolt: He is committed to changing the locals' hostility toward us, because in order for Zeno to maintain a long-term presence there, fostering good relations with the locals is essential.

Bertolt: In the grand scheme of things, his approach is correct.

Bertolt: Family, country, and military—he is loyal to these "old-fashioned" ideals, and that is precisely what we need.

Bertolt: In these turbulent times, comrade, a brave and loyal heart shines brighter than a thousand suns.

Bertolt: But he is simply too young, too ... impetuous and naive.

Hassan: Boss ...

Bertolt: We remained vigilant. The fearless Hassan was leading the way with comrades from the region.

Bertolt: They seemed to know every hill and tree in the area.

Bertolt: Recruiting local auxiliaries was a wise move. These amiable local allies have done much for Zeno and deserve proper recognition.

Hassan: There's only one path forward. We'd better be careful.

Lilya: Want me to take a look from the sky?

Hassan: Don't, comrade. If you fly up there and a gun is pointed at you down here, you'll be an easy target.

Hassan: My people have hunted eagles in these mountains here, for thousands of years ...

Lilya: Tsk. The Red-38 is no bird. Are you giving your people too much credit, or are you doubting my ability to fly?

Bertolt: Hassan's right, don't expose yourself unnecessarily. Stay behind the group near Aleksei, and cover our rear.

Lilya grumbles, but obeys the order and returns to the back of the group.

Hassan: Doesn't it seem a bit too quiet, boss?

The wind roars into the distance, sweeping through the entire valley.

Hassan kicks a pebble off a cliff, watching it land in a riverbed below the mountains.

In the distance, a majestic mountain peak shines in all its glory, its snowy top sparkling under the blazing Juhalerat sun.

The mighty Hindu Kush, where even eagles dare not fly.

Hassan: I'd prefer it if I had a few locals to chat with. Slow down, boss, I'll take a few men ahead, you follow.

Hassan gestures and calls out in the local tongue. The few locals from the auxiliary forces follow him.

Bertolt: They were adept at mountain warfare, but they clung to their own firearms, unaccustomed to Zeno's arcanum weaponry.

Bertolt: These comrades from Juhalerat were more resilient than other soldiers, and they knew the importance of obedience. Hassan seemed well respected by them.

Aleksei: Why do they get to go to the front? I can do that too.

Bertolt: Because they know the terrain, and you don't.

Lilya: Just follow your orders, Aleksei.

Bertolt: Are we headed in the right direction, little falcon chick? Take out your arcanum trinket and give it a look.

Lilya: About two kilometers to go.

Aleksei: In a straight line?

Lilya: Right.

Aleksei: It'll take about two hours on foot. There's nothing but mountains here, and if not mountains, then trees, and if not trees, then rocks.

Bertolt: And if not rocks, then people.

Bertolt: Our people, their people.

Bertolt: Comrade Lilya pointed the way as Hassan cleared the path ahead. We made our way over the hill and continued on a dirt road between the mountains.

Bertolt: After a narrow pass flanked by rock walls, the mountain trail became more winding. But ahead, we were greeted by houses and watchtowers.

Bertolt: It was then, gunfire erupted from both the front and rear of our formation.

Bertolt: D**n! All hands, battle positions!

Bertolt: Hassan!

Before Hassan can react, a shot splatters the eye that was aimed directly at him.

Bertolt: Aleksei's quick reflexes and exceptional marksmanship saved his comrade just in time.

Aleksei: Watch your back, Comrade Hassan.

Hassan: Oh, thank you, Aleksei! Thank you!

Aleksei: One of our comrades has been hit!

Soldier: 【Yelling in local language】

Soldier: It hurts, it hurts so much! Aaargh!

Hassan: Brother!

Hassan tries to save a comrade caught between two enemies, but his hand is too slow.

The curved blade cuts through a familiar face before Hassan's eyes, revealing a jumble of red and white. It then slashes downward, narrowly missing his fingers.

Lilya: $*&@!

Bertolt: Don't let their blades touch you!

Lilya: Bring it on! Hah! Let's see what you've got!

In a chaotic skirmish like this, Lilya has a clear advantage—she can fly.

The enemy won't have the chance to lift their heads to see her; her comrades will make sure of that.

Lilya: You're next!

Lilya: Seriously, how do more of these guys keep popping up?

Bertolt: Lilya, push forward and clear the way! We're retreating to the village ahead!

Bertolt: Aleksei, go cover her on the ground! There are a few taking aim at her!

Aleksei: Roger that!

At the commander's signal, Aleksei and Lilya lead the way, with the rest following closely behind. Hassan and Bertolt are in the rear, ready to provide cover.

Bertolt: Comrade Lilya's heroism saved us from the ambush, but the battle was incredibly grueling because of the narrow terrain.

Bertolt: We even drew daggers and sabers, like the fierce warriors of old who fought alongside the Shah, engaging the enemy in close combat.

Bertolt: Forced by the situation, we had to retreat forward, fighting as we went, and sadly leaving some of our comrades behind ...

Soldier: Wait, Commander! Brother! Friend! Please!

Soldier: Don't leave us behind! Hassan! Hassan!

Soldier: Ahhhhh!!!

Hassan: Boss, should we ...

Bertolt: Hassan looked at me. I knew he didn't want to leave those men behind.

Bertolt: I also knew he didn't want them to fall into enemy hands alive.

Sporadic gunfire fills the air, while a painful silence hangs between Hassan and Bertolt.

Hassan: There's simply too many of them!

Bertolt: We were unable to reach our comrades who were too far behind, and even if we could, they wouldn't have made it home alive.

Bertolt: Sometimes war forces you to do things you have no say over.

Bertolt: Because you simply have no other options.

Bertolt: Do it, Hassan.

Hassan: Understood.

Bertolt: Sometimes, that last bullet we save for ourselves may well come from a comrade's gun.

Bertolt: The wounded captives, especially those under Hassan, would've been seen as traitors and faced a cruel fate.

Bertolt: The enemy caught up to us from behind, their guns aimed at us for a final attack. Hassan and I shot back.

Bertolt: Their numbers were overwhelming, but we kept firing until they trudged over the bodies of their own dead comrades.

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Bertolt: The natives of Juhalerat were exceptional marksmen. They don't ask which animal to shoot, just which eye you want them to hit.

Bertolt: Fortunately, Comrade Lilya returned just in time to detonate a bomb, stopping the enemy's pursuit with shattered rocks.

Bertolt: The rubble buried both our fallen soldiers and theirs.

Lilya takes off her goggles and lands on the ground as the broom's flame goes out.

Lilya: I hope I'm not too late.

Hassan: The timing couldn't have been better. The boss and I would've been finished. Thank you, comrade!

Bertolt: They won't catch up for a good while. What's the situation ahead?

Lilya: There's a village, deserted. Everyone's fled.

Hassan: Understandable, understandable. Who wouldn't run at the sound of gunfire?

Lilya: There's a couple houses that nobody's lived in for a while.

Bertolt: Something happened here not long ago, not surprising for a place like this. And Aleksei and the others?

Lilya: They've cleared a room and are treating the wounded.

Bertolt: Good. Let's head there.

Deserted Village, Juhalerat

Bertolt: There was a watchtower in the village, but it was unclear who built it for defense.

Bertolt: Bullet holes riddled the walls, evidence of a past battle.

Bertolt: Painful screams came from the houses, sounds I knew well—from the halls of military hospitals, on makeshift operating tables ...

Bertolt: Comrade Lilya seemed a bit unsettled, but she'll get used to these experiences in time.

Aleksei: Don't move, comrade, it'll be over soon. I know it hurts a little, but you're a man, aren't you? So bear with it.

Bertolt: How's it looking, Aleksei?

Aleksei: Not great. We've lost five men, three soldiers are seriously injured, and the rest have a range of other wounds.

Aleksei: We are running out of bandages and medicine. We can tear up clothes to use as bandages, but the blood will seep through, and we're almost out of hemostatic agents.

Aleksei's guilt burdened eyes look away. He is now paying for his earlier kindness.

The first aid kit is almost empty. The table is littered with stained bandages and disinfectant tools.

Bertolt: We need to call for reinforcements. Until they arrive, waiting here is the best recourse.

Lilya: And what about the comrades we were supposed to rescue on this mission? Do we have time to look for them, sir?

The officer is troubled, wrestling with the dilemma at hand.

Aleksei: Comrade Lilya is right, we can't just leave the wounded here. If they continue to lose blood ...

Bertolt: Aleksei will stay here to tend to the wounded. Hassan will take a few who can still move to guard the watchtower.

Bertolt: And come, Lilya. Let's talk, just the two of us.

TO BE CONTINUED...

We Have Everything

TWJ-05

We Have Everything

Bertolt: We were forced to retreat to the village. The brave soldiers who bought us precious time ... we must not forget their names.

Interrogator III: Understood, Lieutenant, submit a report later listing the fallen soldiers for Zeno to review.

Interrogator III: Their families will be well taken care of.

Bertolt sighs with relief, a faint smile playing on his lips.

Interrogator III: What happened next? What did you discuss with Lilya?

Bertolt: I tried to call for reinforcements. The base responded quickly, but transporting personnel and equipment takes time.

Interrogator III: Time. I see. Continue.

Bertolt: I briefed Lilya on the priorities of the mission.

Lilya: So, what's our next move? Are we hitting the skies or the slopes?

Bertolt: You should know what our mission is.

Lilya: To rescue the team members, and retrieve some mysterious arcanum documents when we get the chance.

Bertolt: Correct, but I need you to adjust the priorities of these two tasks.

Lilya: Huh? What's that now?

Bertolt: I mean you need to swap the order of these two tasks—prioritize the arcanum documents first, then rescue any stranded personnel if you happen to get the chance.

Lilya: You what?

Bertolt: She was surprised.

Bertolt: They may already be dead. How long has it been since your device has received a new signal?

Lilya: None. Radio silence since the first message.

Bertolt: I don't think the equipment is faulty, but it's been several hours since the last distress call.

Bertolt: Either they're pinned down somewhere and can't move, or they've met their tragic end.

Lilya: Do the others know about this priority switch?

Bertolt: No. They don't need to know.

Bertolt: Right as I said that, she punched me in the nose.

Bertolt: She had to do a little hop.

Bertolt: Tsk!

The officer staggers back, blood trickling from his nose.

She is stronger than she looks.

Lilya: Liar.

Bertolt: You really packed a punch with that one, little falcon.

Lilya: You don't trust them, and you don't trust me.

Bertolt: No, I trust you and Aleksei.

Lilya: And the others?

Bertolt: I trust their loyalty and their fighting ability.

Bertolt: But they don't need to know any of this. Neither does Aleksei, he'd tell everyone.

Lilya: As will I.

She clenches her fist, still wanting to land another blow on her superior's face.

Bertolt: No sacrifice will be made in vain, Comrade Lilya.

... You youngsters sure mature quickly when you've tangoed with death.

Interrogator III: In other words, your squad had two objectives at the time—to recover the arcanum documents and rescue the relevant team members.

Bertolt: Correct. This mission came directly from the admiral's office.

Hearing this, the interrogator turns and signals the clerk to leave the room.

Now, there's just one other person in the room.

Interrogator III: Let's talk about these documents, Lieutenant. What could possibly justify the sacrifice of so many soldiers to retrieve them?

He picks up the pen and waits.

Interrogator III: Please maintain your candor, Lieutenant. Speak.

Bertolt takes a deep breath and resumes his account.

Bertolt: My mission was to find and retrieve the descendants of an ancient arcanist family who were lost in the Central Asian region before the "Storm" arrived.

Interrogator III: Was the source of this intel reliable?

Bertolt: I don't know, but my orders were clear. Maybe it was some kind of deal between the higher-ups and "them."

Bertolt: Zeno's soldiers were deployed here as mercenaries, receiving compensation for their services.

Bertolt: Equipment, funds, personnel, access to local bases, and information about the arcanists.

Bertolt: In the wake of the "Storm," we were under immense pressure to rebuild the arms academy. To secure resources, we had to do questionable things that ultimately tarnished our name.

Interrogator III: Necessary evils. I understand. Go on.

Bertolt: In 1964, the French conducted an excavation at the ruins of Ai-Khanoum in the north.

Bertolt: It was an ancient Hellenistic city, lost under the sands of Inner Asia for nearly two thousand years.

Bertolt: Some of the artifacts were sent to Paris and some to the local museum. Then, war broke out.

Bertolt: After the city was occupied, a batch of documents was secretly smuggled out and hidden in the mountains.

Bertolt: Since the spring of this year, our people have been discreetly searching for these documents. And finally, we have a lead on them.

Interrogator III: Go on. What does this batch of documents contain?

Bertolt: Treasures of the Aegean Sea.

Bertolt: A family tree, maps, diaries, archives, and epitaphs belonging to a family of Western arcanists who settled in Central Asia.

It is an incredible adventure, spanning thousands of miles and over the course of two millennia.

Bertolt: Their forebears rode with the Macedonian god-king as he conquered the known world. After the king's violent death, they shifted allegiances among several successors.

Bertolt: When the one-eyed general triumphed in Gabiene, these fickle and war-loving veterans became part of his forces.

A volatile, unpredictable army. No wise man would ever grasp that blade without a hilt.

Bertolt: After that, the arcanists within the army were sent east with their old comrades, gradually fading into the mountains and the annals of history.

Bertolt: But they did not disappear. These bellicose descendants of arcanists later merged with the rising Sogdian tribes, and continued to thrive along the desert trade routes for centuries.

Bertolt: Chasing their ancestors' shadows, they stumbled upon the ancient city of Ai-Khanoum and set up a small arcanist commune nearby. But as fate would have it, the early century's penchant for war scattered them once more.

Bertolt: My mission was to track down and bring back the descendants of this tribe, with these documents serving as vital clues.

Bertolt: Zeno needs these arcanists.

The officer takes several gulps of hot water, seemingly anxious about revealing the truth.

Interrogator III: Have you told Lilya about all this?

Bertolt: Yes, she's in the loop, as I told you earlier.

Interrogator III: Okay. I see.

The interrogator presses a button under the table and the clerk steps back into the room, resuming her place.

Interrogator III: Continue, Lieutenant. What happened next?

Lilya: Are we really risking so many lives just for a few measly cottontails?

Bertolt: Eight hundred thousand lives were once sacrificed for just ten kilometers of land.

Bertolt: Though that's not quite the right comparison. That was a foolish battle.

Bertolt: Sacrifice is necessary if the result is worth it, little falcon.

Lilya: Are you willing to sacrifice yourself?

Bertolt: I am.

The officer pulls out his gun without hesitation, prepared for what he knows is coming.

Lilya: What do you want me to do now?

Bertolt: Just understand the priorities of our mission, and never forget them.

Lilya clenches her fists and spits on the floor.

Lilya: Yes, sir.

Bertolt: I understand your frustration, but a mission is a mission, and orders are still orders.

Bertolt: Besides, we need to think about what to do next. We have a lot of wounded to take care of.

Just then, Aleksei bursts through the door, eyeing the two from a distance.

Aleksei: Sir! You're bleeding! And what's with the gun?

Bertolt: I fell. It was nothing.

Lilya: Yeah. Fell onto my fist.

Aleksei: Uh, what?

Bertolt: Don't worry about it. What's the matter, Aleksei?

He tucks his gun into his coat and wipes the blood from his lip.

Aleksei: Earlier, Hassan mentioned herbs in these mountains that can stop bleeding. Maybe I can go find some.

Bertolt: It's too dangerous to go alone. Besides, you don't know the lay of the land.

Lilya: I can come.

Hassan: What are you all talking about? Let old Hassan in on it, eh?

Aleksei: Hassan should know the way.

Hassan: Way? What way? I'm not catching your drift.

Lilya: Aleksei and I are thinking of fetching some herbs. We're running low on medicine.

Hassan: Hmm, that could work.

Lilya: You know these mountains well?

Hassan: Like the back of my hand! I was scampering about these slopes before I could even talk!

Aleksei: That settles it! Let the three of us give it a try, sir!

The officer hesitates.

Bertolt: Having more helping hands would've certainly made things easier, but the war and the "Storm" have cost us dearly.

Bertolt: I had planned to wait for reinforcements before moving out, but time was ticking, and dusk was closing in.

Bertolt: Spending the night there was out of the question, so I gave these brave soldiers the permission to go.

Bertolt: ...

Bertolt: Alright, you have two hours.

Bertolt: Get back before the sun sets behind that mountain, or you're on your own.

Bertolt: How are the wounded, Aleksei?

Aleksei: We've done all we can. I gave the last of the medicine to the others, and now I have an empty box that can hold a lot.

Lilya: What are we waiting for? Time's a-wasting, fellas!

Hassan: Just the three of us, ready to take on the world! Stay tuned for our epic success, haha!

Bertolt: Bring your radar, Lilya. And if you happen to come across our lost comrades along the way, retrieve them.

Lilya: You got it!

Bertolt: They set off, and I was left there to wait. To wait for reinforcements, for their return, or perhaps for the enemy's vengeance.

He calmly lowers his head and pauses for a moment.

Bertolt: Before long, I went looking for them. As soon as I heard gunshots on the road, I followed the sound with our men, but it was too late.

TO BE CONTINUED...

You and Us

TWJ-06

You and Us

Interrogator II: So, Lieutenant Bertolt briefed you on the real objective, and then you, Aleksei, and Hassan teamed up to carry out an independent operation. Is that correct?

Lilya: Yes.

Interrogator II: Very well, we'll corroborate your account with Aleksei's and Bertolt's.

Interrogator II: And you hitting the Lieutenant—that really happened?

Lilya: Yeah, I socked him good. I was gonna go for round two, but then Aleksei waltzed in and it wouldn't have been good form to deck your CO in front of the lads.

The interrogator struggled to stifle his chuckle.

Interrogator II: You've certainly got spirit, Comrade Lilya.

Interrogator II: Go on, then. What happened next? What did you three run into?

Lilya: After gearing up, Hassan led the way, Aleksei and I followed. The three of us headed deeper into the mountains.

In the Mountains, Juhalerat

Hassan: Watch your step, friends, don't let the thorns prick you.

Aleksei: I can't believe you grew up in a place like this, Comrade Hassan.

Hassan: That's why I eventually left for the city to seek a different life. Haha!

Hassan: I was the first from our village to go to the city! I've always been something of a pioneer, you know!

He radiates with pride. A mountain-born maverick, unyielding and audacious.

Lilya: We trekked through the mountains and wilderness, moving from tree to tree and slope to slope.

Lilya: We struggled to keep up with Hassan, whose nimble and sure movements resembled that of a mountain goat.

Hassan: Hey, keep up! Am I going too fast, comrades? Should we take a breather?

Aleksei: A breather? Not a chance! Our comrades are waiting. Keep moving!

Lilya: I'm fine.

Hassan: Whenever there's fighting, the locals hide until it calms down, and then they come out.

Hassan: The more daring might strip the dead. A simple canteen can be a valuable find for a struggling family.

Aleksei: This place is unbelievably poor.

Hassan: Poor people have their ways. After all, this is the life we were all born into!

Hassan: It was like this before you came, and it will be like this after you leave.

The words leave Aleksei disoriented, as if his passion had been poured onto the lifeless stones here, only to be met with indifference.

Aleksei: Stop. Hear that?

Hassan: Hm?

They stop. Lilya takes out the radar and checks their position.

They are getting closer to the signal.

Aleksei: Shh. Listen carefully, comrades. It's a faint woman's voice.

Hassan: Do you have the ears of a fox, boy? Because I don't hear anything.

Aleksei: That way! Move it! Someone might be able to help us with the herbs!

Hassan: Hey, slow down!

Lilya: I ran after them. Aleksei sprinted into the distance, reaching the edge of the forest.

Aleksei: It's you! I never expected to see you again!

Aleksei: Are you okay? Hmm, it looks like you can walk now. Hassan, does she understand what I'm saying?

Hassan chambers his gun and cautiously approaches the woman.

Aleksei: Not this again, Hassan! We saved her before, and she's unarmed, just like last time!

Lilya: Hassan seemed to have a deep distrust of the mountain people.

Lilya: I guess they marked him a traitor, you know, working for Zeno and all.

The armed man approaches, speaking the local dialect. He questions the woman, who utters a few words for him to translate.

Hassan: She needs money because her sheep were blown up. If you can pay her, she can help you find who you're looking for.

Lilya: How does she know we're looking for someone?

Hassan relays Lilya's message to the woman.

She speaks and gestures, tears falling, as if both crying and not crying.

Hassan: She saw people dressed like you enter the cave yesterday. Several of them.

Hassan: They were injured, and her sister is caring for them. She was too terrified to tell anyone ...

Hassan: Because the enemy would never spare her or her sister if they found out.

Aleksei: After the mission, she could come back to the base with us. It wouldn't be hard for her to find work in the city.

Hassan: Stop it with your excessive kindness, brother Aleksei. I'm begging you.

Aleksei: If what she says is true, then Zeno is in her debt.

Hassan: *sigh* What do you think, little comrade?

Lilya: Hassan shirked the decision to me. My heart softened for a second, I guess, and I agreed with Aleksei.

Aleksei: I should still have some money on me.

Rummaging his pockets, he pulls out a crumpled local banknote and hands it to the woman.

She hesitates, not wanting to accept.

Aleksei: Is she ashamed to take our money?

Hassan: No, what you're giving her is worthless paper. Over here, you'll have to give her some "real" money.

Hassan: Aw man. Guess I'll handle this.

Hassan reluctantly retrieves a crumpled bill from the sole of his shoe and hands it to the woman, uttering a few words.

Hassan: Now she'll guide us.

Averting her eyes from Aleksei, the woman limps ahead. He wants to talk to her, they can't get past the language barrier.

Aleksei: You see, Hassan? Being kind to the locals does pay off.

Aleksei: With the support of the locals, Zeno's work here will be much smoother in the future.

Lilya: She's leading us the right way. In the right direction, at least.

Lilya: We're getting closer to the signal.

Aleksei: Will we find any herbs in the cave, Comrade Hassan?

Hassan: Yes, but not many. These plants prefer sunlight, so they should be mostly near the entrance and in the general vicinity.

Aleksei: Good, it seems we can accomplish two objectives with one action.

The young man is pleased that his earlier deeds have borne fruit.

Good deeds are rewarded, and evil deeds are punished. He firmly believes this.

Hassan: That cave is the one.

The four of them walk to the slope outside the cave, where several shell casings lie scattered about.

The woman speaks with Hassan briefly before limping into the cave by herself.

Hassan: She's asking us to wait while she confirms there's no one else inside.

Aleksei: Does she live around here? We didn't see any villages on the way here.

Hassan: Who knows? She could be a refugee from anywhere. War is everywhere these days, not even the mountains is spared from its chaos.

Hassan: And women have particularly suffered in these tumultuous times.

Hassan: My wife was a refugee who fled from the north. We met after her escape, and we got married. She is such a good woman.

Lilya: Hassan spoke of his wife with the same pride as Aleksei spoke of his family.

Lilya: We waited for a few more minutes at the cave entrance.

Hassan: What if this is a trap?

Hassan: What if she took my money and ran? That's my hard-earned cash!

Hassan: When we get back, you two better vouch for me! I fronted cash for this mission! Zeno should reimburse me!

Lilya: Just then, the woman came back out. She scoped around carefully before signaling for us to hurry over.

Lilya: Hassan led the way, Aleksei was in the middle, and I covered the rear.

Cave, Juhalerat

Lilya: We entered the cave, flashlight in hand.

Lilya: Hassan was very cautious. He handed the flashlight to Aleksei, took out his gun and followed the woman closely.

Hassan: Better stay sharp.

Aleksei: There was a fight here.

Lilya: The ground was littered with bodies and splatters, some of the dead stripped of their coats and boots.

Lilya: These were our guys. The enemy wouldn't be caught dead with these metal tags on their belts.

Aleksei: Were the ones who shot at us wearing clothes they took from here?

Hassan: Most likely.

Hassan: Why can't I hear anyone else around?

Hassan: It's odd. Our people wouldn't just leave their comrades behind.

Lilya: Hassan wanted sound, and sound he got.

Lilya: As we hit a fork in the cave, the woman let out a sudden yell and ran into the shadows.

Lilya: I later learned the meaning of the word she kept yelling: "Revenge."

Hassan: This can't be happening!

Lilya: Hassan pulled the trigger, the woman fell, and we were under fire.

A bullet can end a life in an instant, with the pull of a trigger faster than thought.

It was a less than ideal victory.

Hassan: Arghhh!

Hassan: Hahaha ... getting shot in the leg &@#$ing hurts.

Hassan grips his leg, bloodied by a bullet.

Aleksei: Luckily, the bullet only grazed your leg and missed any major arteries.

Aleksei inspects the wound, relieved to find it less severe than he thought.

Aleksei: Can you walk, Comrade Hassan?

Lilya: I can give him a hand.

Hassan: It hurts, but it's no big deal. I don't need a crutch.

Hassan: They didn't take the dog tags. We have to collect our brothers' tags. We can't forget them.

Lilya: Hassan's face was stricken with sorrow as he yanked the tags with his comrades' names from their bodies.

Lilya: He stumbled while bending over, falling onto a corpse.

Aleksei: Let me help you, Comrade Hassan.

Hassan: No! This is my responsibility. I was the one who brought them out of the village and to this camp. I was the one who shared Zeno's meals with them!

Lilya: Had it not been for the hired mountain folk, Zeno would've struggled to get anything done in that place.

Hassan: When the boss comes with reinforcements, we have to bring them all back. We can't leave them dead here in this cave.

Lilya: That was when I had a feeling—that either Aleksei or myself would be the one to carry back Hassan's tag.

Lilya: Or maybe it would be Hassan to carry back ours.

Lilya: I remembered that scene at the Juhalerat airport before takeoff.

Lilya: We saw black metal coffins being unloaded from a transport plane, each with a tulip on top.

Hassan: How many were shooting at us just now?

Lilya: Three.

Hassan: Did you finish off their bodies with head shots?

Aleksei: I did.

Aleksei: No wait, only two bodies were there!

Hassan: D**n! One got away! Don't let your guard down!

Lilya: Even if he does get away, he'll croak before he gets far.

Hassan: Just stay alert, little comrade.

Aleksei: What now? Go back or go deeper?

Lilya: We're close to the distress signal. Our comrades are somewhere in this cave.

Is it a retrieval of allies, or a retrieval of bodies?

Hassan solemnly takes his money back from the woman's corpse.

The blood-soaked bills return to their place, nestled between Hassan's torn sock and the sole of his shoe.

Hassan: Don't forget to remind Zeno to reimburse me when we get back, comrades.

Lilya: After Hassan got his money back from the woman, he didn't leave right away.

Lilya: He picked up something else from the ground.

Lilya: He stared at it for a while, then tucked it into his pocket.

Lilya: His expression was haunting, a blend of regret and other emotions I didn't quite understand.

Lilya: Aleksei stooped down to help him stand, and Hassan accepted his kindness without protest, for once.

Aleksei: Are you alright, Comrade Hassan?

Hassan: I'm fine. Let's go!

Hassan: "A limp in your gait doesn't determine your fate!"

Lilya: Where'd Hassan learn these sayings, anyway? It sounded exactly like something Aleksei would say.

Lilya: We explored deeper into the dark maze of a cave, our flashlights guiding the way.

Lilya: The battle had left us exhausted and silent, moving real slow.

Lilya: Hassan was collecting the tags of every comrade we found.

They find corpses with pus-filled wounds, flies feeding on the sickly yellow discharge.

Lilya: That wicked, evil poison.

Lilya: Hassan closed the eyes of each body.

Lilya: Whether they were friend or foe.

TO BE CONTINUED...

A Black Tulip

TWJ-07

A Black Tulip

Hassan: I've got a really bad feeling about all this.

Aleksei: Your wound is just a scratch, nothing serious. We'll fix you up in no time once we get back to base.

Lilya: Some of our fallen comrades were still in their Zeno uniforms, lying deep in the cave.

Lilya: Next to them was a knife and another body.

Lilya: With arrows drawn in blood on the wall.

Hassan: Look at the wall, something's scribbled on it.

Aleksei's flashlight swings to the bloodstains on the rocky walls.

Aleksei: They're directions, telling us how to navigate the cave.

Hassan: What if this is another trap!?

Aleksei: I can't hear anyone. Do you know the way through this cave, Hassan?

Hassan: I used to. But now they've turned it into a maze.

Hassan: All these forks and newly dug nooks. I'm lost.

Lilya: Guess we'll trust these arrows as a final gesture of support from our comrades.

Lilya: Let's go.

They continue deeper into the cave, Aleksei supporting Hassan with one hand while holding the flashlight in the other. A soft breeze caresses their faces.

Aleksei: Are we getting any closer?

Lilya: Yeah.

Aleksei: Then these marks must have been left by our own comrades. Horrifying, all this blood.

Lilya: Several gruesome battles were fought here.

Lilya: Our people, the enemy's people, all lay sprawled on the ground.

Lilya: I heard a story once, about a tough guy who went into a maze on some island.

Lilya: He killed the minotaur down there, and then followed a ball of thread given to him by a princess to find his way out.

Lilya: And our guiding thread? The dried smears on the walls.

Hassan: Let's follow them. *sigh* These markings could be signs left by comrades who couldn't break out.

Hassan: Keep your ears peeled, brother Aleksei. One of them slipped away, don't let him get the drop on us.

Aleksei: You can count on me.

Lilya: We saw lots of little stone statues in the cave.

Lilya: Placed on chiseled pedestals, all weathered, some splattered with blood.

Lilya: Kinda gave me the creeps.

Hassan: One, two, three ...

Lilya: Hassan counted the tags in hand, saying each name out loud.

Hassan: Including our losses, sixteen souls in all.

Hassan: D**n it all.

Aleksei: They will not be forgotten.

Hassan: Forgotten? What difference does it make if we remember them? Will that be enough to bring them back to life?

Aleksei: Once the commander gets here, we'll transport the bodies back. They will all be granted dignified funerals.

Hassan: Funerals, hah. They're just shows for the living to see!

Hassan: *spit*

Lilya: I dunno why, but Hassan was really worked up.

Lilya: Meanwhile, Aleksei clammed up, and so we followed the arrows on the wall, deeper into the darkness.

Aleksei: There's light up ahead.

Lilya: We came to a fork in the road. It was dark on both sides, but there was a draft blowing through.

Lilya: The marks end here.

Lilya: There was this huge statue standing there, holding a fire.

Flames flicker off the eyeless statue, casting shadows down the long, dark passage.

Aleksei: Left or right?

Hassan: We could check out one side, then double back to the other.

Lilya: I choose left.

Lilya: There's a draft coming from the left. Can't you feel it?

Lilya's hair flutters gently to the right.

Hassan: That could lead to an exit for all we know. Shoot, how many possible paths are there in this place?

Aleksei: Can your device help us navigate through here?

Lilya: I'm afraid not.

Lilya: We're close, but it's not accurate enough to give us a precise location.

Hassan: Then let's go the way you suggested.

Lilya: Following the path led us to a room-like space, with wind flowing through a hole above.

Lilya: There were barrels, beds, and everyday items scattered about, as if someone lived there.

Lilya: It looked like our fallen comrades had fought there not long ago. The blood was still wet on their equipment.

Lilya: Seems like none of the stuff we're looking for is here.

Aleksei: And what are we looking for? These comrades here are already ...

Lilya: No, it's not them, something else.

Hassan: Like what?

Lilya: A pile of arcanum texts. These courageous comrades must've found what Zeno needed.

Lilya: That's why trouble found them in this cave.

Lilya: Bertolt brought us here to find them. But where are they?

Aleksei: Hold on. Weren't we here to save our trapped comrades?

Lilya: If they're still alive, we'll save them if we happen to get the chance.

Unfortunately, they were too late.

Aleksei: If we happen to get the chance?

Aleksei: That's not what the commander said! Our priority is to save lives!

Lilya: Bertolt told me these orders came from high above.

Hassan: He didn't tell us anything!

Lilya: I dunno. I guess he had his reasons.

...

...

A silence falls between the three of them.

Hassan: The dead can't be saved. We got here too late.

Hassan: Fine, let's find the stuff. Got any idea what they look like?

Lilya: No, but they could be books, or sheets of paper.

Hassan: And where are they hidden?

Lilya: In this cave, I guess, where our friends found them and paid the price.

Lilya: Or else Bertolt wouldn't have deployed one team at the expense of another.

Lilya: The deal wouldn't be worth it.

Aleksei: Are our lives merely calculations of worth?!

Aleksei: I'm going to ask him about this, face to face!

Lilya: While Aleksei and I talked, Hassan quietly tended to the dead.

Lilya: More and more tags filled his pockets.

Lilya: Let's look around here, Aleksei. Keep an eye on the cave entrance, there are still enemies nearby.

Aleksei: ...

Lilya: He was really upset.

Aleksei: Fine, hurry it up. We have to report this to Bertolt, fast.

Aleksei: Curse those arcanists to hell.

Lilya: He muttered something unsavory, but we ignored it and continued to search for what we each needed.

Lilya: For me, that meant turning over rocks and cabinets to find the documents Bertolt wanted.

Lilya: For Hassan, it meant checking the bodies, feeling their pockets and waists for metal tags.

Aleksei: What could possibly be worth risking so many lives for?

Lilya: Something valuable to Zeno. That's what I was told.

Aleksei: Are we being thrown into this mission as pointless, expendable sacrifices, just like our fallen comrades here?

Lilya: I don't think anyone is seen as pointless sacrifice.

Lilya: That would be illogical.

Aleksei: This is not about being logical ...

Aleksei: He shouldn't have lied to us!

Lilya: He didn't lie.

Aleksei: But he didn't tell us everything either!

Lilya: Is withholding the truth the same as lying?

Interrogator II: The answer hinges on the objective.

Interrogator II: Soldiers only need to know their duty, not the reasons behind it.

Lilya: I disagree.

Interrogator II: That's fine. You have the right to disagree and keep it to yourself; plenty of others feel the same way you do.

Interrogator II: But at the end of the day, people still have to follow orders.

Interrogator II: And these people are all Zeno's finest soldiers, and one day you too will be among them.

Lilya: Is Bertolt one of them?

Interrogator II: Lieutenant Bertolt is one of the most important pillars of the Zeno Arms Academy today. I have complete faith in him.

Lilya: I see more than that.

Lilya: It is the soldiers like Hassan and Aleksei, who risk everything at the front, that keep Zeno going.

The interrogator does not answer, but gives Lilya a look of approval.

Lilya: In the heat of my argument with Aleksei, I forgot all about Hassan.

Lilya: Who could've foreseen what happened next?

Lilya: There was no one else in the cave, and Aleksei's flashlight was pointed at the way in.

Lilya: I was looking at Aleksei and the darkness that was behind him.

Lilya: But then it happened, behind me.

Hassan: Are these it, little comrade? They're under this comrade here! The body's still warm ...

Lilya: Hassan called to us and when I turned around, what I saw was something I'll never forget.

Lilya: The "corpse" was alive. Dressed in our comrade's clothes, he stuck a poisoned blade into Hassan's waist and dragged it all the way up to his throat.

Lilya: It was a terrifying wound.

Hassan: AAAHHHHH!!!

Aleksei: Hassan!

Lilya: Aleksei was quick. He pulled out his pistol and fired two shots.

Lilya: One through the forehead, and one through the eye. The "corpse" was now truly dead.

Lilya: Hassan lay flat on his stomach, gasping for air. Aleksei leapt to him and helped him roll over.

Lilya: Hassan ...

Lilya: He was in unbearable agony as the wound split open with alarming speed. Blood spilled out at first, then other things.

Lilya: It was a nasty stench.

The stench of death approaching.

The black and red life force of the gasping man runs down his body, soaking Aleksei's uniform.

Aleksei: No, no, no!

Hassan: Hah ... hah ... What did I tell you ... about wishing you'd died ...

Hassan: Ahhhhhh!

Hassan: D**n it, d**n it! I knew it! I was right!

Hassan: I'm fading fast, brother.

Aleksei: Let me treat you, Hassan. You have to hold on, I'll fix this mess, hold on!

The young man reaches behind him, fumbles, and drops the box to the ground with a hollow thud.

He opens the white box, full of hope.

Only to find it empty.

Lilya: Aleksei was so desperate to save Hassan, he forgot they'd left all the medicine behind.

Aleksei: "We've done all we can. I gave the last of the medicine to the others, and now I have an empty box that can hold a lot."

Lilya: He opened up the empty box, looking like it was the end of the world.

Aleksei: I ...

Hassan: I can't take it anymore ... Urghhhh!

Lilya: I could not imagine his pain. His cries were more terrifying than anything I'd heard in military hospitals or field camps.

Lilya: In fact, they were more like primal, animalistic howls.

Like a bull trapped in a blazing forge, bellowing and begging for release.

Lilya: Hassan said that we should each save a bullet for ourselves.

Lilya: But there was no way he could lift a gun now.

The wound continues to expand.

Hassan: A ... Aleksei ... please ... don't let me suffer through this ...

Aleksei: No! We can take you back to the base, or at least to the cave entrance, and find ... find ...

Aleksei: The mountain herbs, yes! They should still be at the camp, and the commander said reinforcements are on their way ...

Lilya: Even I could see that he was deluding himself.

Lilya: The man was melting. Just how was he going to get home?

Hassan: I beg you ... brother ... make it quick ...

Lilya: He pointed shakily at Aleksei's gun.

Lilya: Aleksei. If you can't do it, I will.

Hassan: Ah ... the "tough cookie" ... haha ... good, little comrade ...

Lilya: I reached for Aleksei's sidearm, but he brushed my hand aside.

Aleksei: Allow me, comrade.

Lilya: Aleksei closed Hassan's eyes, putting the gun to his temple.

...

Lilya: He left no words, no goodbyes.

With a single shot, death claims its prey, who can no longer haunt the living with his tortured wails.

Lilya: Hassan's hand went limp and fell onto the stack of papers beside him.

Lilya: He'd found the stuff Zeno needed.

Lilya: As a soldier of Zeno, Comrade Hassan had fulfilled his mission flawlessly.

TO BE CONTINUED...

Debriefing

TWJ-08

Debriefing

The sound of gunshots eventually draw in a set of footsteps.

Bertolt: Lilya! Aleksei! Hassan! Is that you?

Bertolt's voice echoes through the cave.

Lilya: Bertolt!

Lilya: He followed my voice and quickly found the room, much easier than we did.

Lilya: The sight of Hassan lying next to Aleksei shocked him.

Bertolt: ...

Bertolt: Hassan's courageous sacrifice will forever be remembered. He fought bravely against the enemy and died a hero.

Lilya: Aleksei could not accept Bertolt's portrayal of what had happened.

Lilya: He was too principled for that.

Aleksei: No, Commander. It was I who killed our comrade.

Lilya pulls out a bloodstained stack from under Hassan's body and throws it at Bertolt.

The thick files hit the ground, kicking up a swirl of dust around his army boots.

Lilya: Congratulations, Commander. Mission complete.

Bertolt: You went in earlier than I did, but you came out later.

Lilya: They wouldn't let me go.

Bertolt: Well, it seems you had a pleasant chat. Personally, I hate being questioned.

Lilya: I'm an honest person.

Bertolt: Just like Aleksei.

Bertolt: It's over now. Don't forget about your debriefing report.

Bertolt: Well done, my little falcon. You have survived Juhalerat. Your service on the battlefield is over for now, so you're free to return wherever you please.

Lilya does not reply. She looks back at the interrogation room, where the doors are now shut.

Bertolt: How are you feeling about all this?

Lilya: Not how I thought I would feel.

Bertolt: Of course, of course. For those who have never experienced war ...

Bertolt: War is often romanticized as a beautiful, idyllic symphony.

Bertolt: Until you're staring down the barrel of a gun, being mocked for your naivete.

Bertolt: And you become just another tally, a statistic on the government's ledger.

Lilya: Hassan ...

Bertolt: Zeno will take care of his wife, you can be sure of that.

Lilya: Was this all "worth" it, Commander Bertolt?

Bertolt: He was a joyful man. I cannot deny that we became good friends during our time together.

Bertolt: The truth is, Hassan will serve as excellent promotional material. He'll become a true model.

So utilitarian, interest-oriented, and calculating.

Bertolt: Work for Zeno, earn your merits, and your family will be treated well.

Bertolt: And for them, family and blood are above all else.

Lilya: ...

Lilya: Two critters with one stone.

Lilya: Let's go see Aleksei.

They walk to the interrogation room and peer at the silent young man through the window.

He notices the people outside, looks up, and halts his signing.

Lilya: He sees us. Aleksei is smiling.

Bertolt: I told you, this really isn't that big of a deal. It's just that he insisted on making this report himself.

Bertolt: Have you ever met someone who'd openly confess, "I am the one who shot our fellow comrade"?

Bertolt: I had no intention of sending him to a tribunal, but he was hell-bent on the notion.

Bertolt: *sigh* Such a stubborn young man.

Lilya: Having principles isn't easy.

Bertolt: He didn't belong there. Juhalerat was not the right place for someone like him.

Bertolt: Or perhaps I should say he was not the right kind of person for a place like Juhalerat.

Lilya: Semantics.

Bertolt: Don't worry about Aleksei. A young man like him will no doubt earn the admiral's favor.

Bertolt: And this case will end up on the admiral's desk, I promise.

Bertolt: As for you ...

Bertolt: Your flight leaves tomorrow morning. The luggage in your room is already packed.

Lilya: How nice of you to do that.

Bertolt: Because you're going to take this story back to the academy.

Bertolt: You will walk off the plane with coffins topped with black tulips.

Bertolt: And you will tell your bratty little classmates ...

Bertolt: That perhaps one day, we might all end up in a black metal box.

Lilya: ...

Bertolt: The front line still needs me, so this is it. I hope we'll have the chance to meet again, comrade.

Lilya: Best of luck to you, Commander.

Lilya: I almost forgot. I've got something for you. Aleksei left it with me before you got here.

Lilya: This. It was Hassan's.

Bertolt: ZENO
A-150756

The officer cradles the name tag in his palm.

Bertolt: I don't remember making this for him. "ZENO" ... The tags of auxiliary forces should not have these letters engraved on them.

Lilya: Aleksei told me he and Hassan got it secretly engraved last month.

Lilya: Hassan had always hoped to become a real part of Zeno. He loved being a part of this "big family."

Bertolt lowers his head in thought.

Bertolt: He will have a real one made. I will fight to have his name inscribed in the Hall of Merit at our headquarters.

That dark and glorious corridor, lined with the names of those who died in battle and during the "Storm."

Bertolt: He will rest in the Zeno Cemetery as a true soldier of Zeno, with a dog tag bearing his name.

The officer turns and walks away, holding the keepsake tightly in his hand.

The sound of a soldier's boots echoes down the hall. Lilya takes one last glance at the room where her comrade had seemed so relieved.

Inside, Aleksei eagerly awaits his fate, while Zeno eagerly awaits him.

THE END